```
$test = 'something';
$val = ($test) ?: 'default';
var_dump($val);
```

```
Output:
string(9) "something"
```

The usual type coercion gotchas apply when `$test` is implicitly cast to a `bool`, as the following trick demonstrates:

```
var_dump(
    false ?: null ?: 0 ?: '0' ?: 'default'
);
```

```
Output:
string(7) "default"
```

This form is known as *ternary chaining* and will evaluate to the first (loosely typed) non-false value in the chain. A neat trick that will save a few lines of code.

## Null-Coalesce

PHP 7.0 added a similar convenience feature that operates on `null` values (rather than falsy), which allows for the easy assignment of variables from others that might not exist or have null values. This is the *null coalescing* operator `??`, it is an implicit logical test on the left-hand operand: and it works like this:

```
$val = $notDeclared ?? 'default';
var_dump($val);
```

```
Output:
string(7) "default"
```

It is possible to chain these operations together:

```
$val = $notDeclared ?? $stillNotDeclared ?? 'default';
var_dump($val);
```

```
Output:
string(7) "default"
```